CONCEPT PAPER

Title: Learning Analytics Feedback Dashboards and the Engagement of Working Graduate Students in Blended Courses

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Background and Rationale

Working graduate students in blended courses leave traces in the learning management system every time they open a module, submit an activity, or post in a discussion forum. Learning analytics dashboards turn those interaction traces into feedback that students and instructors can read. Graduate programs at the university have adopted the learning management system, yet students receive little feedback on how their participation compares with the expectations of the course. This concept paper proposes to study whether a feedback dashboard changes how engaged graduate students are in blended courses.

Statement of the Problem

The study asks how a learning analytics feedback dashboard relates to the engagement and persistence of working graduate students. It asks what students do with the feedback, and which dashboard features they find useful.

Objectives

1. Describe the learning management system activity of working graduate students in blended courses. 2. Determine the relationship between dashboard use and student engagement. 3. Explore how students interpret dashboard feedback and how it affects their study habits.

Methodology

The study uses a sequential explanatory mixed-method research design. Data collection begins with learning management system activity logs and an engagement questionnaire answered by graduate students enrolled in blended courses. Regression analysis will test the relationship between dashboard use and engagement. Semi-structured interviews with selected students will then explain the quantitative results, and interview data will be coded by theme.

Significance and Scope

The findings can guide the Graduate School in deciding whether to provide dashboards to students and instructors. The scope is limited to graduate students in one academic year and to courses delivered in a blended format.

References

Bodily, R., and Verbert, K. (2017). Review of research on student-facing learning analytics dashboards. Matcha, W., et al. (2020). A systematic review of empirical studies on learning analytics dashboards. Jivet, I., et al. (2018). License to evaluate: preparing learning analytics dashboards for educational practice.